

core-guide

The QuakeReady Core Guide™

The 90-Second Earthquake Survival System — Your 4-Phase Quake Protocol™ Roadmap

Welcome. You bought this system because the ground moved — again. Another cluster of quakes hit the news, your phone buzzed with a shake alert, or you felt a jolt and realized you had no idea what to actually *do* in the ten seconds you had.

Here’s the truth that changes everything:

You don’t need to panic, move away from fault country, or bolt everything to the studs this weekend. You need a system — one that runs on autopilot when the ground starts moving and you have less than 90 seconds to act.

This Core Guide is the map for the entire QuakeReady™ system. Read it once (20 minutes), then let the other seven tools do the work. By the end of this document you will know exactly what to do right now, this weekend, and for the rest of your time living anywhere the ground can move — and why most people’s “plan” (there isn’t one) fails in the first five seconds of a real event.

Part 1 — What You’re Actually Up Against

The situation in one paragraph

Earthquake clusters are not rare “someday” events — they are a recurring pattern in every seismically active region, and swarms (multiple small-to-moderate quakes in days) are often followed by a stronger event or simply repeat for weeks. Most people who live in quake country have never done a real drop-cover-hold drill, don’t know where their gas shutoff valve is, and have a “go bag” that is really just a backpack with an old granola bar in it. Meanwhile, the data is consistent everywhere seismologists study it: **the people who survive with the least injury and the least chaos are the ones who had already rehearsed the first 90 seconds and prepped the first 72 hours.** There is no way to predict exactly when a big one hits. There is a completely proven way to be ready when it does.

Why “right now” matters

Factor	What it means for you
Quake swarms/clusters	Multiple small quakes often precede or accompany the pattern that raises everyone’s

	attention — the exact moment people search for a plan
No warning window	Most quakes give 0-10 seconds of P-wave lead time (or a ShakeAlert-style buzz) — your <i>trained reflex</i> is the entire plan
Aftershock risk	The period after a felt quake carries elevated risk of a second, sometimes larger, event for hours to days
Infrastructure exposure	Gas lines, water heaters, unsecured furniture, and unmounted shelving are the #1 cause of preventable injury — not collapsing buildings
Household unpreparedness	Most homes have zero minutes of rehearsed response and under 24 hours of self-sufficient supplies

Know your enemy: the three moments that matter

Not all of “earthquake safety” is the same skill. The system you’re about to run targets all three phases, because each one fails differently if you’re unprepared:

1. **The shaking itself (0-90 seconds).** This is a reflex problem, not a thinking problem. If you have to *decide* what to do while the ground is moving, you’ve already lost several seconds you didn’t have. This is trained, not remembered.
2. **The immediate aftermath (first hour).** Gas leaks, damaged utilities, aftershocks, and family separation are the highest-injury, highest-panic window. This is a checklist problem — you follow steps, you don’t improvise.
3. **The following days (72 hours to weeks).** Power outages, water disruption, store shortages, and aftershock swarms mean self-sufficiency matters. This is a supply and communication-plan problem, solved once and maintained lightly.

Why this matters: a fire extinguisher doesn’t help you during the shaking, and knowing “drop, cover, hold on” doesn’t help you if your water heater tips and floods the kitchen with no one knowing how to shut the gas main. The 4-Phase Quake Protocol™ handles all three moments — which is why it works where “just get a go-bag” doesn’t.

Part 2 — The 4-Phase Quake Protocol™: How the System Works

Earthquake readiness happens in four sequential phases. Master each one and your household moves from “we’ll figure it out” to “we already know exactly what to do.”

PHASE 4 – RECOVER	(the weekly rhythm that keeps the system alive)
PHASE 3 – AFTER	(utilities, aftershocks, communication, shelter)
PHASE 2 – DURING	(drop, cover, hold on – the trained 90-

second reflex)

PHASE 1 – BEFORE (home hazard removal + go-bag + family plan)

YOU (the protected family, at the center)

Phase 1 — BEFORE: Preparation

Goal: remove the hazards that cause injury and build the supplies/plan you'll need before you ever feel the first jolt.

- Run the **20-Minute Home Hazard Hunt** (Tool #2) once — it finds every tip-over, fall, and gas-leak risk in your home.
- Build the **72-Hour Go-Bag** (Tool #3) for every household member, plus one for the car. This is the single highest-leverage prep action, full stop.
- Set up your **Family Emergency Plan** (Tool #5) — meeting points, out-of-area contact, and the “if we’re separated” protocol.
- Locate and label your gas, water, and electrical shutoffs. Know exactly where the wrench is (see Tool #6 for the exact shutoff procedure).

The three preparation mistakes that leave people exposed: 1. Bolting nothing to the wall (bookshelves, water heaters, TVs — the things that tip, fall, or leak are the actual danger, far more than structural collapse). 2. A go-bag with expired water, dead batteries, and no cash (ATMs and card readers go down with the power grid). 3. No agreed meeting point or out-of-area contact — kids at school, parents at work, phones down, and no plan to reconnect.

Phase 2 — DURING: The 90-Second Reflex

Goal: react correctly in the window you actually have — which is seconds, not minutes.

- Run the **Drop, Cover, Hold On drill** (Tool #4) as a physical, timed family drill — not just something you read once. Muscle memory beats memory.
- Know your **location-specific response**: indoors, in bed, outdoors, in a car, in a high-rise, at work — each has a specific correct move (all covered in Tool #4 and Tool #7).
- The rule that does 80% of the work: **Drop where you are. Cover your head/neck under sturdy furniture or against an interior wall. Hold on until the shaking stops — do not run for a doorway or run outside.**

Why “drop, cover, hold” beats every myth: running outside during shaking is how people get hit by falling debris, glass, and masonry — the leading cause of quake injury is being struck by falling or flying objects *inside*, not building collapse. The “triangle of life” and “stand in a doorway” myths persist online and get people hurt. Tool #4 gives you the evidence-based move for every situation, with no guessing.

Phase 3 — AFTER: The Critical First Hour

Goal: handle the immediate danger — gas, aftershocks, injuries, and communication — before you do anything else.

- Check yourself and others for injuries first (Tool #6 gives the triage order).
- Check for gas leaks by smell/sound *before* using any switch or

- open flame; know the exact shutoff procedure (Tool #6).
- Expect **aftershocks** — treat every one like the first: drop, cover, hold on again.
- Use text, not calls, to check in with your out-of-area contact (networks jam with voice calls; texts get through more reliably).

Phase 4 — RECOVER: The Weekly Rhythm

Goal: make the system automatic so it survives real life — busy weeks, travel, new house, growing kids — instead of decaying into “we’ll get to it.”

- The **12-Week Quake-Ready Tracker** (Tool #8) turns the system into a 10-minute- per-week habit with a family duty roster.
 - Rotate stored water and check expiration dates on food/meds on a schedule, not on memory.
 - Re-run the **Drop, Cover, Hold On drill** every 90 days — kids grow, routines change, and drills fade from memory faster than you think.
-

Part 3 — The 7 Rules of Earthquake-Ready Living

Print these. Put them on the fridge. This is the whole system in seven sentences.

1. **Drop, cover, hold on — every time, no exceptions.** Do not run outside, do not stand in a doorway, do not try to reach another room.
 2. **Secure the tip-overs.** Anchor bookshelves, water heaters, and TVs; the falling object is the danger, not the building, in the vast majority of quake injuries.
 3. **Build the 72-hour bag before you need it.** Water, food, meds, cash, flashlight, radio, first aid — for every person, plus the car.
 4. **Know your shutoffs.** Gas, water, electrical — locate them, label them, keep the tool nearby, and know the exact procedure (never turn gas back on yourself).
 5. **Plan your reconnect, not just your escape.** Meeting point, out-of-area contact, and a text-first communication rule beat “we’ll just call each other.”
 6. **Expect the aftershock.** Treat every jolt after the first like a new event — drop, cover, hold on again, every single time.
 7. **Drill it, don’t just read it.** A physical, timed family drill every 90 days beats reading this guide once and assuming everyone remembers.
-

Part 4 — The First 72 Hours: Your Launch Sequence

You don’t need to wait for the weekend. Here is exactly what to do, in order:

Tonight (20 minutes): - [] Read the Aftershock & Post-Quake Safety Card (Tool #6) once so you know the exact gas-shutoff and injury-triage steps before you ever need them. - [] Do the quick version of

the Home Hazard Hunt: walk each room and note every unsecured tall/heavy object. Don't fix yet — just count. You'll be surprised.

Tomorrow (1-2 hours): - [] Run the full 20-Minute Home Hazard Hunt (Tool #2) room by room. - [] Anchor the top 3 highest-risk items you found (usually: bookshelf, TV, water heater strap) or schedule the anchoring this week. - [] Start the 72-Hour Go-Bag (Tool #3) — even a partial bag tonight beats an empty closet during the next event.

This weekend (1 hour): - [] Finish the Go-Bag for every household member + the car. - [] Fill out the Family Emergency Plan (Tool #5) — meeting points, contacts, the out-of-area text-tree. - [] Run the physical Drop, Cover, Hold On drill (Tool #4) as a family, timed. - [] Set up your 12-Week Tracker (Tool #8) and assign the duty roster.

Done. You are now running the system. Your household has moved from “we'd probably panic” to “we already know exactly what to do” — and that shift is the entire difference between chaos and calm when the ground moves again.

Part 5 — What the System Is Not

Straight talk, because you deserve it:

- **This is not a promise that nothing bad will happen.** It's a dramatic reduction in preventable injury and chaos — the part you control — during and after a quake.
 - **This is not professional structural engineering or emergency-management advice.** It is preparedness education aligned with FEMA/Ready.gov and USGS public guidance. For structural retrofitting or your specific building's risk, consult a licensed engineer or your local building department.
 - **This is not an endorsement of every “earthquake gadget” sold online.** Tool #7 and the checklists separate what emergency-management agencies actually recommend from what marketing departments invented. You will save money by not buying hype.
-

Part 6 — Your Tools, Your Order of Battle

#	Tool	When to use it	The one job it does
1	This Core Guide	Now, once	The map — know the system
2	20-Minute Home Hazard Hunt	This week	Finds every tip-over/fall/leak risk you have
3	72-Hour Go-Bag Checklist	This week	Builds the supply kit for every person + the car
4	Drop, Cover, Hold On Drill	This weekend + every 90 days	Trains the 90-second reflex until it's automatic

5	Family Emergency Plan	This weekend	Locks in meeting points + the reconnect protocol
6	Aftershock & Post-Quake Safety Card	Keep it visible	Exact steps for the critical first hour
7	Work/Car/Travel Playbook	Before you need it	The correct move wherever you are, not just at home
8	12-Week Quake-Ready Tracker	Every week	Makes it automatic + assigns the family jobs

The One-Paragraph Summary

Earthquakes give you seconds, not minutes, and the households that come through with the least injury and the least chaos are the ones who trained the reflex and built the supplies *before* the ground moved. The QuakeReady™ 4-Phase Quake Protocol™ attacks the problem across all four moments that matter — before, during, after, and the ongoing recovery rhythm — so that when the next swarm, jolt, or “big one” hits, your family already knows exactly what to do, and does it without thinking. Run the 72-hour launch sequence, keep the weekly rhythm, and turn “we’d probably panic” into “we already know exactly what to do.”

QuakeReady™ is an educational preparedness system. It is not professional structural, engineering, or emergency-management advice, and does not replace guidance from FEMA, Ready.gov, USGS, or your local emergency management agency. Always follow local building codes and manufacturer instructions for any anchoring hardware or safety equipment. For specific structural concerns, consult a licensed engineer.

© 2026 QuakeReady™. All rights reserved. Personal use license — one household.